

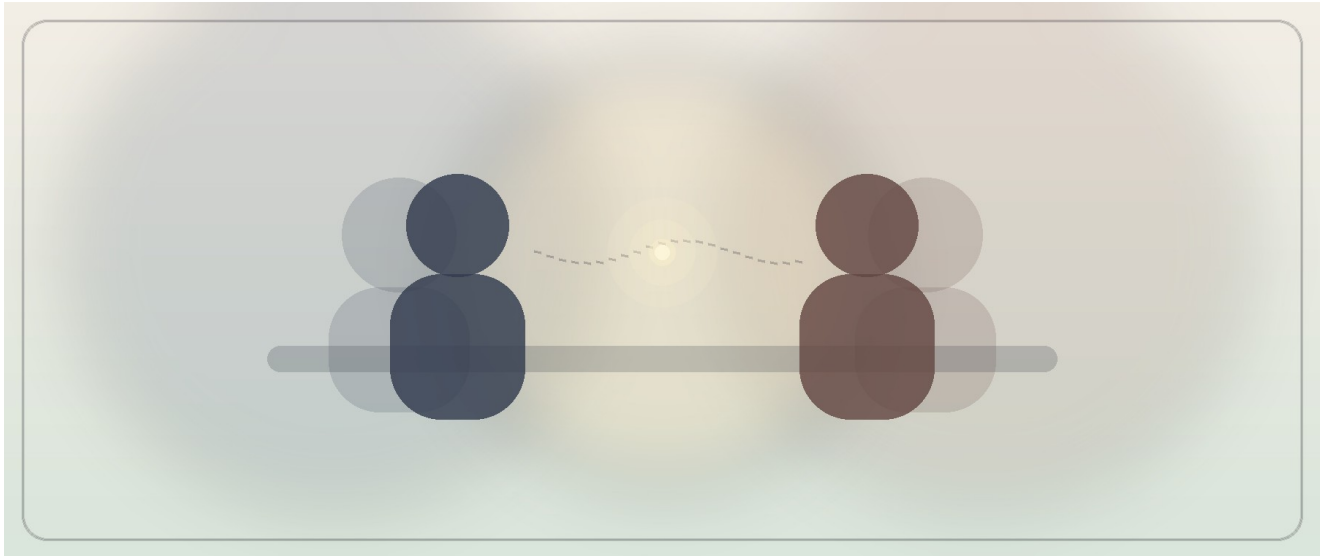
A Collection of Short Stories

Stories Before Thought

Bedtime Stories for My Mother



Volume I



Story One

How Truth Remains Honest

A short story about conversation, trauma, and the promise to return to the ideal



Once, by this point, she would already have left.

Not always with her feet. Sometimes not even with her eyes. She would remain across from him, sitting in the same chair, holding the same cup of tea, nodding in the same places, but the person who might have met him would slip out of the body. He had known that departure for years. It was not a shout, not a slammed door; it was quieter than that, and therefore harder to prove. He would say one sentence, and she would still be there. Then he would say another, and suddenly she would not.

She was his mother, but sometimes, when the conversation became too deep or too precise, she became someone protecting herself from him. And he, younger then, did not know how to tell the difference between a person protecting herself and a person erasing him. So he learned to speak quickly. He learned to push the sentences out before the window closed. He learned to turn every thought into a small courtroom in which he was both the accused and the only witness left.

Over the years, this changed. Not all at once. Not like in stories where a person understands something and from that moment becomes new. There were months in which it seemed nothing had changed, and then one small conversation in which she stayed one minute longer. There were periods in which he spoke more quietly, and then returned to shouting from an old place. But each time, even when everything nearly returned to its old shape, something did not return completely. She learned not to flee immediately. He learned not to speak only in order to be heard.

This did not mean the hunger disappeared from him. The hunger to be seen, to be believed, to be told at last that he had not invented himself - that hunger was still there. But it no longer sat at the head of the table. It was like a child behind him, tugging at his sleeve, while another person, older and more tired, tried to speak on behalf of the thing itself.

That evening they sat in the kitchen. The light over the table was too yellow, as if it had been made for meals and not for truth. His mother held a cup of tea that had gone cold. He knew the conversation mattered, though he could not explain why. They spoke of large ideas - God, unity, the possibility that every person carries something of the whole within them. On these subjects she went farther with him than he expected. Sometimes she smiled. Sometimes she said, 'Yes, that is interesting.' Once he would have seized such a sentence as permission to live. Now he only heard it and continued.

He felt he was close to the point. Not to victory. He no longer wanted to defeat her, or so he believed. He wanted to say the sentence as it existed inside him before anyone touched it. Before it became an explanation. Before it became a response. There was a bright point there, small and almost embarrassing in its simplicity: that a person progresses when he can hold another point of view without erasing his own, and that perhaps truth itself is tested not when it is accepted, but when it is interrupted.

'What I am trying to say,' he began, and stopped.

He stopped not because he did not know, but because he knew too much. Words always arrived afterward, slightly soiled, like shoes entering a clean room. One more moment, and he might have said the thing as it was.

Then she said, 'But don't you see that you do it too?'

Her sentence was not cruel. That was the problem. If it had been cruel, he could have placed his anger somewhere simple. But she had not come to destroy. She had come to defend. Only her defense struck exactly where his sentence had not yet been born.

He breathed. At first he was almost pleased by the breath. Here, he thought, is the repair. Once I would have leapt. Once I would have proven. Now I am giving her room. Now I see her boundary and do not break it.

'Maybe,' he said. 'Let's look at that.'

And he truly meant it. At least in that moment. He saw that it was not only his mother speaking to him. Her memory of him was speaking too: the son who was too sharp, the boy who had turned pain into argument, the man who entered a conversation with sentences that seemed too perfect to her, as if no room remained for her to be imprecise. And he, on his side, was not speaking only to her. His memory of her was speaking with him: the mother who interpreted him before he had finished being born, the mother who knew how to turn an explanation into a defense, the mother in whose presence every truth had to be spoken quickly or else appear as a plea for mercy.

There were at least three people in the room: he, his mother, and all the previous conversations that had not ended. Perhaps there were more. Perhaps every sentence between them passed first through an old place, and only afterward reached the person to whom it had been sent.

She spoke. He listened. Not perfectly, but he listened. One could even see progress in it: she did not leave, and he did not demand that she understand immediately. He let her finish. When she finished, he gently returned to his sentence.

'I think the question is not who is right here,' he said. 'But whether we can feel the other person's point of view without...'

'But you say that as if you already know what my point of view is,' she interrupted.

This time his breath was no longer clean. It was still a breath, but it kept accounts. He felt the small ledger open inside him: Once I gave. Twice I gave. How many times must a person give before he is finally allowed to be?

'Right,' he said. 'Maybe I am doing that too.'

The words were beautiful. The tone almost succeeded in being beautiful as well. But beneath the 'maybe' hid something else: You are doing it again. And he heard it. Not with his ears. In a deeper, more shameful place, where a person knows the truth about himself before he is ready to admit it.

She did not get up. This, too, had to be witnessed. Once, by this stage, she would have already left inwardly. Now she stayed. Not fully open, not soft, not free of her fear of him - but she stayed. And he knew he had to see that. Not only the wound. The progress too.

But knowledge is not always strength. Sometimes it is only a small light showing a person exactly where he is about to lose himself.

They continued. She said another thing. He allowed it. She objected. He corrected himself. She said he was making a move. He said he was not making a move. She asked why everything had to be so deep. He almost said, Because all my life I had to dig to find a place where I would not be dismissed, but he swallowed the sentence. Not because it was untrue. Because he knew that if he said it now, he would use the child inside him as a stone.

Instead he said, 'I understand that it can feel that way.'

He heard himself. The sentence was true, but it was no longer fully alive. It was the sentence of a person trying to remain ideal after the ideal had begun to drift away from him. Outwardly he was more patient than he had been at the start of the conversation. Inwardly he had begun to gather stones.

And then, for the third or fourth time - he no longer knew how to count - she interrupted him precisely when he felt the point returning to him. The same bright point. The same sentence that, strangely, had not given up on him.

'You simply can't accept criticism,' she said.

Something in him tore.

'Do you see?' he said, too quickly. 'This is exactly it. Exactly when I reach the point, you have to come in. You don't allow anything to be born unless it is born in a shape that is comfortable for you.'

The room went quiet.

Not because he had lied. That was the terrible thing. He had not lied. He had even said something very close to the truth. But the truth had come out of him with a different face. Not the face by which he had known it when it was still a bright point inside him. Now it had teeth.

Immediately he wanted to take it back, but not because he did not believe it. Because he saw what he had done to it.

'Wait,' he said. 'No. I don't want it to sound like that.'

But it already sounded like that.

And the second sentence, the one that came to repair it, was more pathetic than the first. Because the first, at least, had been alive. The second was already an attempt to arrange the furniture after the guest had seen the house burned.

His mother looked at him with that look of hers, the look that was not entirely anger and not entirely pity, and was therefore harder than both.

'You see?' she said quietly. 'In the end, it is impossible to talk to you without you turning it into something.'

He wanted to say: But that is exactly what happened to you. He wanted to say: You turned it into something too. He wanted to say: I am still trying to return.

But no sentence was first anymore.

And suddenly he understood that they were no longer speaking to each other. Not really. She was speaking to the son who had once wounded her with words too sharp, and he was speaking to the mother who had once interrupted him before he had managed to believe himself. They sat in the same room, but each was answering someone who was no longer there in exactly the same way.

'Maybe we should stop,' he said.

She lifted her eyes to him.

'Not because I give up,' he added quickly, and immediately heard the fear in that speed. 'Not because I have nothing to say. I do. But if we keep going now, I think we will only keep speaking with each other's wounded place. Not with each other.'

The sentence was true. It was also weak. He knew it. It came out of him like a man raising a white flag after he had already fired.

'So what?' she asked. 'Every time it is hard for you, you stop?'

He smiled slightly, not because it amused him, but because pain had, for a moment, found a bearable shape.

'No,' he said. 'Every time I feel I am about to use my truth to hurt you - I will try to stop. And then return. Cleaner.'

She was silent.

He knew she had not accepted it. Not truly. Perhaps she had heard it. Perhaps she had written it down somewhere distant, somewhere not yet reachable. But she did not leave. Even now, after the outburst, she did not leave. And once, that would not have been little.

'We will continue another time,' he said.

It was an honest promise, and therefore almost impossible. Because they both knew the other time would not arrive clean. It would arrive with them. With this memory, with the sentences said wrongly, with the things swallowed, with her tone, with his anger, with everything each of them still believed the other had done to them.

And still, it was a promise. Not because he believed that next time they would succeed. Because he no longer wanted to use failure as proof that there was no point in trying.

His mother nodded, but did not allow the ending to be clean.

'Fine,' she said, in that cutting-tired voice of hers. 'Just remember that stopping every time is also a way not to deal with things.'

He wanted to answer. Of course he did. The wound in him already stood with a sentence prepared.

But behind it stood something else, weaker than anger and no less true than it: the desire to return.

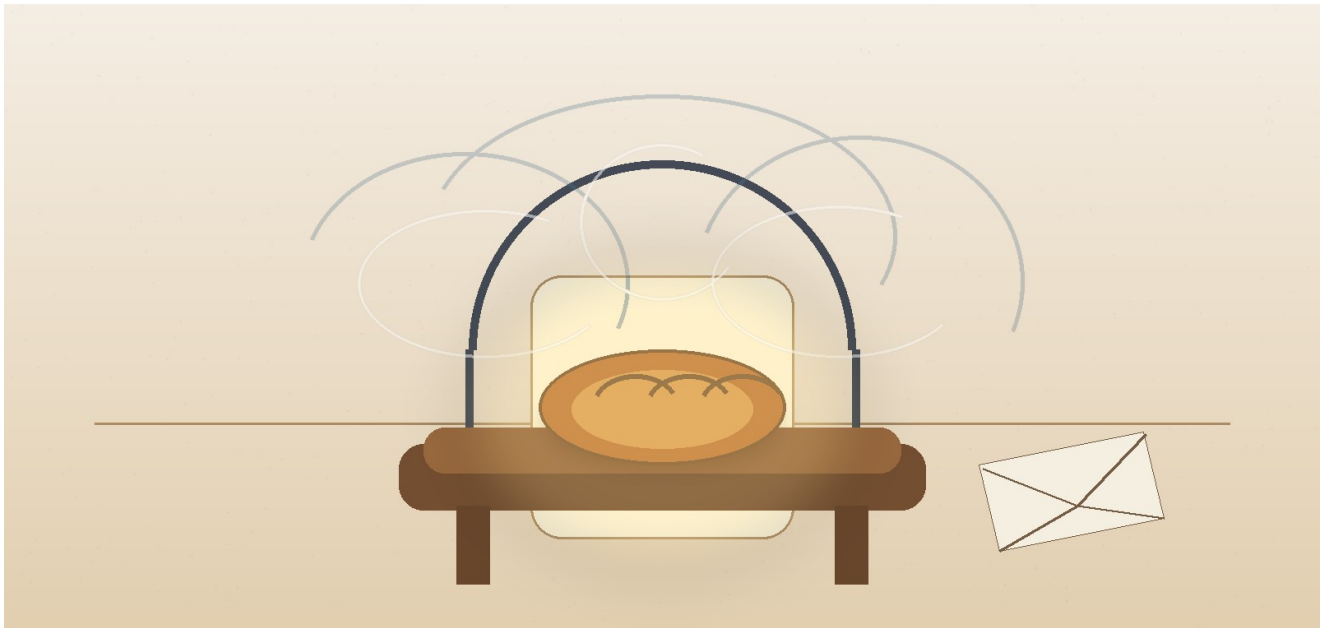
So he was silent.

Not the silence of victory. Not the silence of a clean person. The silence of a person who remembered, too late but still in time, that truth does not remain honest because no one wounds it.

It remains honest only if the person who carries it refuses to turn it into a weapon, even after being wounded.

And that, on that evening, was all that remained to him of the ideal.

Not the ideal itself. Only the promise to return to it, after the noise had stopped.



Story Two

True, But Not Just

The Air Seller



On the first day, he placed one basket of bread on the counter, one pot of soup, and a small bowl of yellow fruit that had not grown on any tree.

He did not write a price.

People asked him how much it cost, and he could not answer without feeling that he was insulting the thing itself. How much does bread made from air cost? How much does soup cost when behind it there is no purchased field, no exhausted worker, no truck burning fuel, no locked warehouse, no hunger waiting its turn? He could have placed a little box for donations. At least donations, people told him. So that people would respect the food. But he hated that sentence, as though a person only respected bread after proving he could have paid for it.

So he wrote on a piece of cardboard:

If you are hungry - eat.

If you are full - take some to someone hungry.

On the first day, seven people came. By the third, there was a line. On the seventh, an inspector arrived. On the tenth, a reporter. On the twelfth, the editors of Matter & Taste called. And on the thirteenth day, he heard the name the public had given him for the first time: the air seller.

He almost laughed.

Not because it was funny, but because he was not selling anything.

He could have lied, or at least helped the world lie to itself. He could have said the bread came from a rare grain, that the soup was based on an ancient algae, that the yellow fruit grew in secret greenhouses in the south. People would have believed him more easily. The world likes a miracle as long as it arrives dressed as tradition, price, or scarcity.

But he told the simple truth, and that was his first mistake.

“It is made from air,” he told an old woman who blessed him after eating two slices.

She stopped chewing.

The taste had not changed. The bread had not changed. Its warmth was the same warmth, its softness the same softness, and the fullness already beginning to move through her body did not retreat. But the word air entered the room, and from the moment it entered, the bread was no longer bread. It became an insult.

“You mean you are selling us air?” she asked.

“I am not selling,” he said. “And I am not giving you air. I found a way to turn something that does not nourish into something that does.”

She looked at the slice as though it had begun lying to her.

Then the others came. Not all of them angry. Some afraid, some curious, some carrying that thin kind of ridicule reserved for things a person does not dare examine too closely. He opened his notebooks. He showed the process. He explained how he drew from air what was not food and assembled from it carriers the body knew how to accept. He hid nothing: not the transitions, not the temperatures, not the first failures, not the times the bread had been beautiful but empty, or nourishing but bitter, or filling for only an hour.

“Show me where it fails,” he said to anyone willing to sit across from him. “Maybe I am missing something. Maybe there is a point where the body accepts it and is harmed later. Maybe some part of the process is unstable. I am not asking you to believe me. I am asking you to show me where it breaks.”

But most of them were not looking for the place where it broke. They were looking for the place where they could stop listening.

“Food cannot be made from air,” they said.

“But if it nourishes?” he asked.

“Then it is even more dangerous,” they answered.

At first he thought it was only intellectual laziness. Later he understood that it was a deeper fear. Not the fear of hunger. The fear of what would happen if a certain hunger turned out not to be

necessary. The fear of what would break if an ordinary man, in a small shop, proved that the world could have been larger than its habits.

The name Dr. Eitan Weiss reached him before the man himself did.

Weiss was the editor of *Matter & Taste*, the most important journal in the place where food science met money, government, agriculture, ethics, and pride. He was not one of those men who raised their voices. Men like him did not need to shout. A rejection from his mouth sounded almost like a medical diagnosis: clean, polite, and final.

When Weiss invited him to a meeting, some people told him it was a good sign. If Weiss was willing to taste, they said, then at least he was considering it.

He knew they were wrong. There are gatekeepers who do not open a gate when they invite you inside. They only want a closer look at the thing that must be locked out.

Still, he went.

He brought one loaf, a small pot of soup, and three pages. Not a presentation. Not a declaration. Not a story about the end of hunger. Only the process, the tests, and a question.

Dr. Eitan Weiss tasted the bread and said nothing.

It was the first moment in the entire meeting when he seemed less intelligent. Not because his intelligence had left him, but because it had not moved quickly enough to protect him. For one brief moment, before words returned, his face belonged only to his body. And the body, in a quiet and humiliating betrayal, recognized the bread.

Then Dr. Weiss returned. Not the man who had tasted, but the institution inside which the man had learned to speak.

"It is good," he said.

The hero's heart opened cautiously.

"And that is exactly the problem."

He did not understand at once. Perhaps he did not want to.

"Taste is not the problem," Weiss said. "Nor is nutritional value the only problem. This is your childishness: you think food is whatever feeds cells."

"And what is it?"

"Food is the continuation of a world. Soil, season, animal, plant, labor, scarcity, distribution, oversight, responsibility. Food is the way reality agrees to become life. And you come and say: none of that is necessary. I have air."

"I am not saying reality is unnecessary," he said. "I am saying air is part of it too."

Weiss looked at him with an almost sorrowful expression.

“That is a beautiful sentence. That is why it is dangerous.”

“Dangerous because it is beautiful?”

“Dangerous because it makes people forget that the world does not become just merely because someone has found a way around its boundaries.”

He breathed. He wanted to remain clean. Not to step into the posture of the genius no one understands. Not to tell himself I am right because I am right. He returned to the only question that still felt honest.

“Then show me the boundary I crossed.”

“The boundary is that you are asking us to accept food that does not come from food.”

“But if it nourishes?”

“Then the problem is more serious.”

Weiss took a spoonful of soup, this time a smaller one, as though the body was no longer entitled to full testimony. Then he placed the spoon aside.

“Do you understand what frightens me most about you?” he asked.

The hero was silent.

“That you may truly want to help.”

The sentence wounded him more than the mockery of the street. Fraudsters are easy to handle. A person who wants money, ownership, control - one can fight him in a language the world knows. But a person who wants to give food away for free introduces a different fear. If he is lying, he is dangerous. If he is not lying, he is more dangerous.

“I want people to eat,” he said.

“You want people to eat through you.”

“No. I want the way to be open. I am willing to give away the process. Publish it. Hand it over.”

“To whom?” Weiss asked. “To every person who wants to feed a city from air? To everyone who will later sell hunger dressed as a miracle? To every cult that says its bread does not need soil? You think giving cancels power. Sometimes it only hides it better. Whoever controls food controls the world, even if he gives it away for free.”

He knew there was truth in that sentence. That was what made Weiss difficult to hate. Weiss was not stupid. He was not a man who feared because he failed to understand. He understood enough to be afraid, and did not know that fear was the thing speaking through him.

There, in that room, the hero saw it for a moment. Not in words. More like seeing a dark fish move under water. Weiss recognized the genius of the thing. Not in his mind, perhaps not by that name.

But his body recognized the bread, and his intellect hurried to build around that recognition a wall of ethics, history, responsibility, and state.

“Give me a criticism,” the hero said. “Not a defense of the world against the possibility that I am right. A criticism. Where does it fail?”

Weiss closed the folder.

“Your failure,” he said, “is not that the food does not nourish. Your failure is that you use a thing that is not nourishing in order to create a thing that nourishes. Do you understand? Even if you succeeded, the success itself contains the problem. There are things that, if they occur, do not prove that the world has changed. They prove that something in the way we judge the world is about to break. And I am not certain you have the right to break it.”

After the meeting, Weiss published his article.

The title was: The Fraud of Fullness: Why Bread From Air Is Dangerous Even If It Is Not False.

The article did not state that the bread lacked nutritional value. Weiss was too careful for that. Instead, he wrote a sentence the newspapers loved to quote:

“I cannot determine that the product lacks nutritional value. It is precisely for that reason that I consider it more dangerous.”

Then came the grades.

Nutritional value: not publicly verifiable.

Reliability of source: failed.

Social responsibility: very low.

Institutional risk: extreme.

Potential for innovation: high, and therefore unacceptable at this stage.

The grades did what shouting would not have done. They dressed fear in the shape of order. Within a week, an investigation opened. Within two weeks, the shop’s license was frozen. Within a month, the Recognized Nutritional Source Regulation passed: no person may market an edible product whose primary source is a substance not recognized as an approved natural or industrial nutritional source, even if that substance has undergone conversion, processing, or synthesis.

The regulation did not name him.

Everyone knew his name.

On the day they closed the door, people stood outside the shop who wanted to eat, and people who wanted to see him fall. There were also those who did not know why they had come. Hunger and curiosity look similar from a distance.

An inspector pasted a white notice on the glass. The machines inside were still working. The smell of bread filled the room like testimony that was not allowed to be admitted.

Dr. Weiss arrived toward evening. He did not need to come. Perhaps he told himself he had come to make sure everything was done properly. Perhaps he even believed it.

“Are you satisfied?” the hero asked him.

It was an unclear question, and he knew it immediately.

Weiss did not answer.

“You are not checking whether I am wrong,” the hero said, each word sharper than the last. “You are checking whether I am allowed to be right. You are not afraid of frauds. You are afraid that if I am not a fraud, everything you have protected your whole life is only a fence around fear.”

Weiss’s face changed. Not much. Only enough for the hero to understand that he had struck a place he had not meant to prove he could reach.

And the sentence was true.

That was the problem.

He was true, but not just. He had spoken a truth that had found no place, and so it became an injury. Not a lie. Not a simple mistake. A small injustice done in the name of a great precision.

He wanted to take the sentence back, but not because he no longer believed it. Because he saw what he had done to it. His truth had come out of him not as a bridge, but as a knife asking to prove that it knew where to cut.

Weiss looked at him for too long.

“Naomi Sahar would have liked you,” he finally said.

“Is that a compliment?”

“It is a warning.”

He knew the name. Everyone knew the name, if they had spent enough time near things that were not supposed to be believed too early.

Once, years earlier, Dr. Naomi Sahar had opened the first table for the Black Water affair. One man claimed he had found a way to turn poisoned water into drinkable water at almost no cost. The institutions laughed, then warned, then refused to test. Naomi did not say he was right. That was what they forgot afterward. She said only that one must not kill a claim before understanding what it lives on.

For months, it seemed possible that she had been right. People drank and did not fall ill. Samples passed the first tests. Experts began to fall silent. Then it was discovered that the man had hidden a clean water source, altered samples, mixed a small truth into a large lie.

Since then, they remembered only the door she opened, not the fact that in the end she herself closed it.

Some said she saved science from cowardice. Some said she gave fraud a table, a chair, and dignity. Both sides said it with the same fear. Since then, she had disappeared from committees. Not because she had stopped believing in truth, the hero thought, but because she had learned something terrible: a truth that arrives too early and a clever lie arrive in the world wearing the same disguise.

That night, after the street emptied, he remained alone in the closed shop. He still had twenty loaves, three pots, and one machine that continued to turn air into something the body knew how to accept as food. He did not know whether that was enough to prove anything. He did not know whether proof was even the thing that was missing.

On the table lay an old article by Naomi. He had found it a week earlier, searching her name out of anger rather than hope. One sentence in it had been marked in pencil, perhaps by someone else:

A truth that arrives too early does not need believers. It needs a place where it may be examined without being punished for its shape.

He read the sentence again and again. At first he was angry at it. Then afraid of it. Then he understood that he did not yet know whether he was seeking a place for truth or a stage for himself.

That was the cruelest test, because it could not be performed in a laboratory.

Was he willing to give away the process if no one remembered him? Was he willing for the bread to enter the world through other people, slowly, without a story about the genius who fed the city? Was he willing for Naomi, if she answered, not to tell him he was right but to ask him to surrender being the center of the thing?

He did not know.

But he knew that the thing he held could no longer enter the world through the door by which he had tried to bring it in. Not through a small shop. Not through a cardboard sign. Not through goodness alone. Goodness too large, when it arrives without form, looks to the world like power. And perhaps the world is sometimes right to fear power, even when power comes with bread.

Toward morning, he packed one slice in a small box.

Not the most beautiful. Not the most impressive. A simple slice, almost dry at the edge, like a thing that was not trying to seduce anyone. Beside it he placed three pages: the process, the tests, and one question.

He did not write: I have proven it.

He did not write: You were wrong.

He did not write: The world will apologize to me one day.

He wrote:

I am not asking you to believe me. I am asking you to show me where it breaks.

Then he added a line, erased it, and wrote it again:

And if it does not break, help me find a place where it can be said without breaking others.

He wrote her name on the envelope not like a man writing to salvation, but like a man writing to someone who had already been disappointed by salvation and yet might still remember the way to the first room.

Dr. Naomi Sahar.

If there was anyone in the world who could know the difference between a truth that had arrived too early and a lie that had hurried to disguise itself as truth, it was her. And if even she did not know, he thought, perhaps the place had not yet been found.

Not that there was no place.

Only that it had not yet been found.

In the morning, before he could regret it, he sent the package.

He was true.

But he knew he would remain wrong until his truth learned how to become just.

Until then, he would keep looking for its place.



Story Three

Red Causes Dread

When Truth Must Be Wrong



The Garden of Hope was an excellent place to live.

Not perfect, of course. In the Garden of Hope they were careful to say that there was no such thing as perfect, because perfection made people feel late for something. But someone arriving from outside, seeing the soft paths, the low apple trees, the white benches, and the birds singing only up to the edge of politeness, would sometimes say that it was practically paradise. Then someone would gently correct him: not paradise, the Garden of Hope. Paradise sounded too final. A garden bed could still be turned over.

At the entrance stood a small sign:

Welcome to the Garden of Hope.

Please leave knives, snakes, and unnecessary comparisons at the gate.

Beneath it, in smaller letters, a clause had been added over the years:

Sharp truths must be softened before serving.

No one knew who had written that clause first, but everyone agreed it was wise. They did not lie in the Garden of Hope. That was not their virtue. Any place can announce that it opposes lies. The virtue of the Garden of Hope was different: there, truth had learned to walk slowly, so it would not step on people who were still learning how to stand.

There was Avner, the keeper of quiet. It was not an official title, because an official title like that would have made people laugh, and laughter in the Garden of Hope was treated with appropriate seriousness. But everyone who needed to know knew: if something began moving too quickly in the heart of the place, they called Avner.

He did not always know what to do. Usually he did not. But he had a small gift: he knew the difference between living quiet and quiet that was hiding fear. The first was soft. The second was too orderly.

David Saten did not enter the story on the first day people noticed him.

They had noticed him long before they began speaking about him. That was one of the problems. If a person appears suddenly and immediately causes disorder, it is easy to tie the things together. But David Saten was there like another tree beside the path, like a bench placed slightly too close to the fountain, like something that may always have been there and had only now taught people how to look at it.

He was pleasant. Not pleasant in the eager way, not one of those people who hand out smiles and later charge interest on them. Truly pleasant. He thanked the person who passed him salt. He rose when an older person approached. He did not enter conversations that had not invited him. When boxes needed carrying, he carried them. When silence was needed, he was better at it than most people.

And his hair was red.

Not the red of shouting. The red of something that remembered fire but tried to be light. In the morning, when the sun was low, his hair looked almost like a halo that had fallen slightly too far down. In the afternoon, when the wind rose from the trees, two locks would lift above his forehead. Those who did not fear him saw hair that disobeyed combs. Those who already feared him saw something else.

The first problem was recorded beside the Fountain of Rephrasing.

Miriam sat there with a bowl of soup and with Yoav, her husband, who knew how to hold silences very comfortably. David passed them, stopped only because her spoon had fallen, picked it up, rinsed it in the running water, and returned it to her.

“Thank you,” Miriam said.

“Gladly,” David said.

That was all.

At least that is what was written in the first report of the Committee for Serenity. Later some claimed he had smiled too much. Others claimed he had not smiled at all, which was worse. Miriam herself said that nothing had happened, and in doing so made everyone less calm.

That evening Yoav asked her whether she was happy.

She did not know why he was asking.

He said he did not know either.

The next day both of them looked tired. They had not fought. They had not shouted. They only spoke with the care of people no longer certain whether their carefulness was love or habit. David was not there. At the same time, he was helping repair a bench at the far end of the garden.

That was the second problem: even when he was not there, he could already be mentioned.

Then came Bathsheba.

Her name alone was the kind of thing Avner would have preferred not to write down beside David's. In the Garden of Hope they disliked unnecessary comparisons, and yet there were names that carried a story before a person had opened his mouth.

Bathsheba worked in the small kitchen, where apples were peeled without hurry and bread was cut as if even crumbs deserved respect. David did not court her. He whispered nothing. He did not ask her to stay after the meal. Only once did he hold a tray for her because it was too heavy, and he thanked her when she took it back.

A week later Bathsheba told Avner she thought she had fallen in love with him.

"Did he say something to you?" Avner asked.

"No."

"Did he give you a reason?"

"No," she said. "That is exactly the shame."

Avner did not know what to write. Love was not an offense in the Garden of Hope. Nor was it a mistake. But love born without invitation, beside a man who had done nothing, was one of the things the place did not know how to protect itself from.

Avner was called to examine the matter.

"Did he say something to her?" he asked.

"No," Yoav said.

"Did he do something?"

"No."

"Then what happened?"

Yoav looked toward the grass. In the Garden of Hope, the grass was too green for ugly answers.

"I don't know," he said. "For a moment she looked as if she remembered there was a world."

Avner wrote the sentence down, though he did not know under which section.

Then came Noam.

Noam was one of those people who were grateful in an orderly way. Every morning he said he was grateful for the work in the healing garden, for friends, for rain, and for the absence of rain, as needed. His gratitude was real, but a little tired. Like a shirt washed too many times and still refused the mercy of being thrown away.

One day David sat beside him while Noam tied seedlings to thin posts.

“You work beautifully,” David said.

“Everyone works beautifully here,” Noam answered.

David nodded.

“You sound tired of being grateful.”

That was the entire sentence.

Not advice. Not temptation. Not criticism. Not even a particularly sharp truth. A small sentence, almost compassionate, like someone placing a hand on a closed door and asking whether it is a door.

But that night Noam did not sleep. The next day he did not come to the healing garden. On the third day he told Avner he no longer knew whether he loved the work, or only had to love it because he had been saved from something worse.

“Did David tell you to leave?” Avner asked.

“No.”

“Did he say the work was bad?”

“No.”

“Then what did he do?”

Noam thought for a long time.

“He said a sentence I had room to hear but no place to put,” he said.

The Garden of Hope had great difficulty with sentences like that. They were not offenses, but they smelled of consequence.

The children loved David first. Children, in the Garden of Hope, were the unofficial testing department for everything. They did not know how to define danger, but they knew how to feel falsehood. David did not fake anything with them. He repaired a torn kite, taught them to distinguish between a bird that sings and a bird trying to attract attention, and listened seriously to the question of whether apples are offended when people eat them.

“Only if they are eaten without gratitude,” he said.

It was a good answer, until one of the children later asked at dinner whether people are also offended when their lives are lived without gratitude.

No one knew what to do with that.

People began speaking about David in corridors, near trees, while washing dishes. Not angrily. At least not at first. More like people discuss a change in weather that had not been invited.

“He has done nothing,” they said.

“Exactly,” others answered, as if that proved something.

The Garden of Hope was a good place, and so it tried to be fair. They formed a small committee: Avner, Miriam, Noam, two gardeners, one man who had disliked David before it was acceptable to dislike him, and an older woman named Hannah whose role in every committee was to ask whether anyone was hungry.

They called David in for a conversation.

He arrived on time. Plain shirt. Hair combed back, perhaps on purpose. No large smile, no absence of smile. He sat as if he had already decided not to be offended before learning by what.

“Saten,” he said when they read his name from the page. “With an e.”

Avner looked up at him.

“Sorry?”

“People often write it with an a,” David said. “I only correct it.”

No one knew why the small correction failed to comfort them.

Avner began carefully.

“David, we are trying to understand something. People feel things around you that make the place difficult.”

“I know,” David said.

That was not a good answer. Had he denied it, they would have known where to go. Had he defended himself, they would have seen pride in him. But he said I know with simple sadness, and took away their comfort.

“You know?” Miriam asked.

“I see it. People change when I am near. Or perhaps they only stop pretending they are not changing. I do not know how to say that without sounding as if I am accusing them.”

“And are you not?” asked the man who had disliked him.

“No.”

“Do you not enjoy it?”

David looked genuinely embarrassed.

“Enjoy what?”

“This power.”

David looked at him as though he had been asked whether he enjoyed a shadow he could not lift from the floor.

“No,” he said. “I am trying to be less.”

And he truly tried.

In the days that followed, he did not sit near the fountain. He did not speak to anyone alone. He wore gray. He tied his hair back so it would not scatter in the wind. He worked only where he had been asked to work. When children called him, he sent them to someone else. When people complimented him, he changed the subject. When someone looked at him too long, he lowered his eyes first.

It was almost noble.

And it did not help.

On the contrary. Now everyone saw his effort, and the effort became the most discussed thing of all. Why was he keeping away? What was he afraid of? Did he know? If he knew, why did he remain? If he was innocent, why did he behave as if people had to be careful around him?

There are people who, even when they make themselves smaller, only prove how much space they occupy.

The cracks grew. Not dramatically. In the Garden of Hope, cracks knew how to behave politely. Couples did not separate; they only spoke late into the night. Children did not rebel; they only asked questions unsuitable for their age. People did not leave their work; they only began performing it as though someone else was supposed to have lived their lives.

The bad thing happened nowhere, and therefore it was everywhere.

Avner began examining himself. Perhaps they were looking for a scapegoat because it was easier to call one person a problem than to admit that the quiet of the place had been too soft. Perhaps David created nothing, only revealed things already there. Perhaps the Garden of Hope was not paradise, but a place that had learned to postpone pain in beautiful language.

All these possibilities were true to some degree.

That was the trouble with truth. It liked to arrive in groups.

Toward the end, Avner understood why human beings had once invented Satan. Not because they needed a name for a creature that wanted evil. That was too simple. They needed a name for

something harder: one who does not do evil, and yet evil arranges itself around him as if it had been waiting. One whose presence accuses the quiet, even when he himself does not mean to accuse anyone.

But Avner did not say this aloud. Not in committee, not to himself, and certainly not to David. There are names which, once given to a person, make it impossible to see his face again.

On the day of the decision, the Garden of Hope was almost unfairly beautiful. Sunlight fell on the paths. The apples looked ready to be eaten and forgiven. The birds sang exactly enough.

David stood beside the gate with a small bag. No one had asked him to pack. Perhaps he understood before they told him. Perhaps, once again, he was too pleasant.

Avner came to him alone. That had been David's only request: that the decision not become a ceremony.

"We think you need to leave," Avner said.

David nodded.

Not quickly, not slowly. Like a person placing something fragile on a table.

"I understand," he said.

And he truly meant it. That was the final problem.

He understood the decision. He understood the fear. He understood that people in the Garden of Hope had become sadder, more suspicious, smaller beside themselves since he had been there. He even understood, with a kind of quiet nobility, that perhaps a place must protect itself from things that are not guilty.

But he did not understand where he was wrong.

"I did nothing," he said. Not as an accusation. Almost as one last fact he needed to leave clean.

Avner nodded.

"I know."

The wind moved along the path. Two locks of David's red hair slipped free of their tie and lifted for a moment. From one angle they looked like horns. From another, like a small halo that had lost its way.

"Then this is not just," David said.

"Not entirely," Avner said.

David smiled a quiet smile. Not bitter. Not victorious. Only too certain of himself by an almost invisible measure.

"Then I hope one day you forgive yourselves."

Avner wanted to say: And I hope one day you understand.

But he did not say it. Sometimes truth, even when it is correct, must remain behind a little longer.

David left the Garden of Hope without slamming, without cursing, without one last look meant to wound.

Almost like a righteous man.

Only almost.

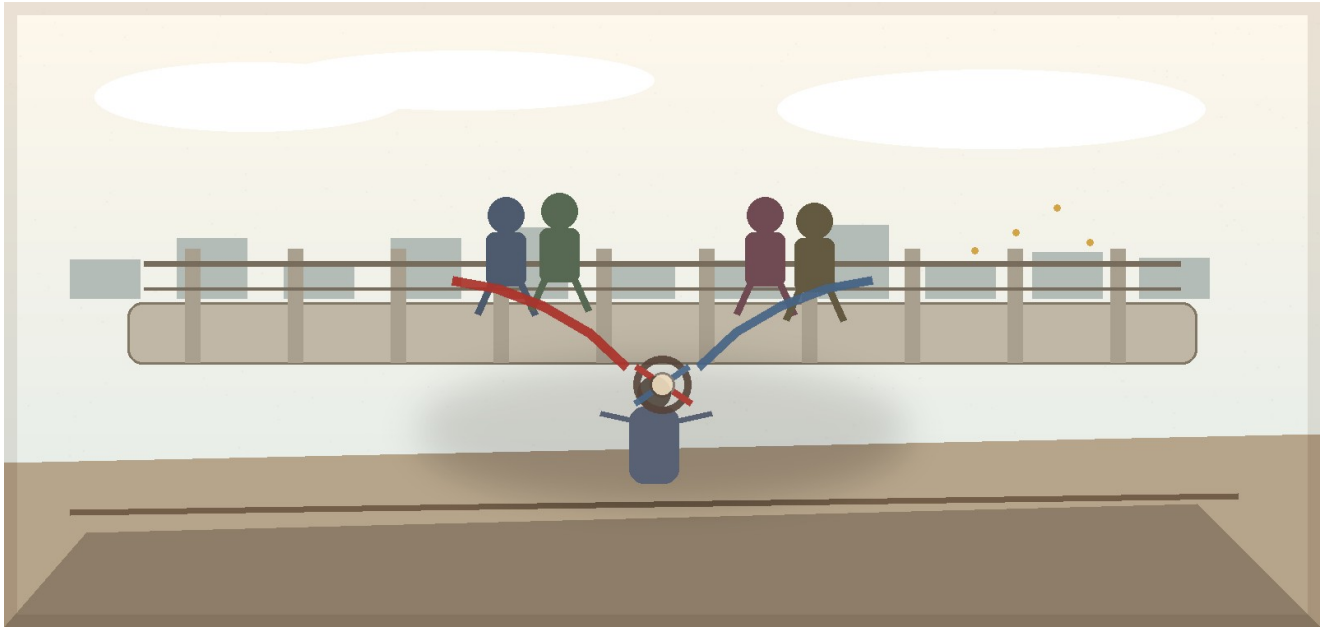
Because deep inside him, in a place so clean it no longer knew how to distinguish itself from pride, he was still certain they were wrong.

The gate closed behind him gently. In the Garden of Hope, even injustices were done carefully.

And quiet returned.

Not cleaner.

Only more possible.



Story Four

Two Strings and a Knot

The Redeemer as the Redeemed



Moshe did not fall because he wanted to fall.

This mattered, though for years he did not know to whom exactly it mattered to say it. He had not walked to the bridge in order to die. He wrote no letter. He said goodbye to no one. He did not make his sadness large enough for anyone to give it a name.

He was fourteen, and fourteen is an age at which pain does not yet know whether it is an event or a personality. Nothing special had happened to him that week. His mother was more tired than usual, his father spoke to him as if he were a list that needed finishing, and at school they laughed about something so small that no one would have been able to remember it later. But Moshe remembered the feeling: as if someone had removed a thin layer of skin from him, and everything in the world touched him a little too much.

That afternoon he took the long way home, the one that passed over the old bridge. Beneath it there was no stream, only a strip of mud and stones, a memory of water. The railing was too low, and the city had promised to fix it since Moshe was in fourth grade, and like most adult promises, that too had become part of the scenery.

He stopped in the middle of the bridge.

Not to do anything. Only because, suddenly, it was hard to continue. Sometimes a person stops not because there is a wall before him, but because inside him the place where one puts the next step has run out.

Then came a horn.

An electric bike, a boy older than him, wet with sweat and panic, swerved along the narrow path. Moshe moved backward too quickly. His foot struck the cracked edge of the pavement. One hand caught the railing. The other found air.

For one moment he hung between two things that did not want him: the bridge above, and the ground below.

He could have pulled himself up. Probably. Later they told him so. Later he told himself so. But in that moment something inside him did not gather itself. There was no decision. Only exhaustion becoming weight.

He understood, with embarrassing simplicity, that he was giving up.

Not because he wanted to die. Because he could not find within himself the small string that says: one more moment.

Four children saw him.

They knew him, more or less. Yael was in his science class. Amir played soccer with boys from his grade. Roni had once copied an answer from him on a test and never said thank you. Neta lived two buildings away, but they had never spoken more than “hi” at the grocery store.

They were not his friends. This was one of the facts the story guarded jealously. If they had been his friends, what happened would have been too easy to understand.

Yael screamed first. Amir ran to him and lay on his stomach, reaching an arm over the railing. Roni shouted at cars to stop, though there were no cars. Neta opened her bag as if the solution was supposed to be inside it.

There was no rope.

There was a long cord from Amir’s hoodie, Yael’s hair ribbon, a thin strap from Neta’s bag, and Roni, who under pressure began tying the wrong things together and then laughed a laugh too short, one that broke in the middle.

“It won’t hold,” Moshe said from below.

“Then you hold too,” Yael said.

They tied two strings and something that was almost a string. The knot came out ugly. Unprofessional. Asymmetrical. Half of it looked like a mistake, and the other half like a plea.

But it held.

Not by itself. Amir pulled. Yael held the knot. Neta wrapped her arms around Amir's legs so he would not slide. Roni shouted sentences of no value that, in that moment, were of enormous value.

"Don't get dramatic on us, Moshe. You're too heavy for drama!"

And Moshe, who began crying precisely because of the joke, found for a moment the string he had not found inside himself.

They pulled him up.

Afterward they all sat on the pavement. Moshe shook. Yael gave him water. Amir said they would not tell if he did not want them to. Neta asked if he wanted them to call his mother. Roni said their knot had been so bad that if the city saw it, it would finally fix the bridge out of shame.

Moshe laughed a little. Not because it was funny. Because his life, which had failed to hold him a moment before, had returned to him through a joke that was not good enough.

After a few minutes they stood up.

There was no oath. No group hug. No music. Amir took his torn hoodie cord. Yael left the ribbon with Moshe without noticing. Neta shook dust from her bag. Roni said, "Okay, don't fall on us again, yeah?"

Then they left.

Moshe remained on the bridge with a strip of ribbon, a little mud on his elbow, and a knot that did not yet know it would grow inside him for years.

At first he tried to be close to them.

Not embarrassingly close. Moshe was too careful a child for visible embarrassment. He said hello in the hallway a little earlier than necessary. He sent Yael a birthday message because he had heard someone say the date aloud. He gave Amir a new pen after his broke in class. He laughed too hard at one of Roni's jokes. He thanked Neta again, months later, when it was no longer clear for what.

They were kind. Usually.

But life at fourteen is full of people who almost became important. There are tests, clubs, crushes, fights, bus rides, conversations that feel eternal and are forgotten by dinner. The event on the bridge became, for them, a strange memory. For Moshe, it became an axis.

In the years that followed, the connection stretched but did not come closer.

When a new social network opened, Moshe sent friend requests to all four. Yael accepted immediately and forgot. Roni accepted after three months and wrote, "Wow, you are ancient." Neta did not see the request until she had already left the app. Amir did not accept at all, not out of malice, but because he accepted almost no one.

Moshe kept sending small things.

Happy New Year.

Happy birthday.

An article he thought might interest Yael.

A short message to Amir when he heard he had joined a combat unit: take care of yourself.

A funny greeting card to Roni after seeing a performance online by accident.

To Neta he once mailed a book without explanation, because he remembered that at fourteen she had said she liked stories in which no one wins completely.

They received these things in different ways. Yael answered with polite hearts. Amir did not answer. Roni sent an emoji. Neta kept the book beside her bed for two weeks before opening it, and then did not know to whom the gratitude belonged.

Moshe did not take offense.

Or he did, and continued.

The two look similar sometimes when done for enough years.

Meanwhile, he succeeded.

At first not in a way anyone from outside would notice. He studied a great deal, because study was a place where he did not have to explain why he was still here. Then he was accepted into a good army unit, then university, then founded a small company with a name that meant nothing to anyone. The company solved a boring problem no one wanted to think about, and for that reason became very important. Money began arriving like rain after one has already grown used to thirst.

Moshe did not become happy immediately. People imagine success enters the soul like light entering a room. Sometimes it enters like furniture too expensive for a house whose walls are still cracked.

But he became stable. Then strong. Then, without planning it, powerful.

Newspapers wrote about him. Conferences invited him to speak. People older than him asked for advice in sentences that began with, "You understand this, of course." He founded a charity. Then another. His name appeared on doors, scholarships, and projects he had no time to visit.

But in the bottom drawer of his desk, inside a small box of old pens, he kept Yael's ribbon and the piece of Amir's cord that remained after the knot came undone. Not because he was sentimental. At least that is what he told himself. Because a person must remember what material his continuation is made of.

Yael became a person who held things.

It began beautifully. She was the one who remembered birthdays, brought soup, called when someone's voice sounded different. She became a social worker, then a team manager, then a

mother, then the only daughter of a sick mother. Everyone said she could be relied on, and did not understand that such a sentence can be either a compliment or a sentence.

She did not collapse in a single day. People like Yael do not collapse all at once. They only remove one more thing from themselves, and then another, so there will be room for other people's burdens, until one day there is no one left to remove anything from them.

On her fortieth birthday she received a small bouquet from Moshe and a card:

Thank you for that knot.

Her husband asked what knot. She said, "An old story." Then she placed the card in a drawer with bills she did not know when she would pay.

Years later, when everything had already begun to grow too heavy, a new consultant came to the center where she worked. His name was short and old, the kind of name that seemed to have existed before anyone invented resumes. In the corridor light there was, for a moment, a copper note in his hair, and then there was not. He asked nothing cruel of her. He only said, with a kindness that contained no visible malice, "You know how to hold people without making them feel held." That week they began giving her more cases.

Amir became a person who did not ask.

After the army he opened a small renovation business. He had a strong body, good hands, and the stubborn belief that a person who works hard should need no favors. At first it succeeded. Then came a bad partnership, a client who did not pay, a loan taken out to close another loan. He learned how to smile at bankers. It was one of the things he hated most about himself.

When Moshe sent him a message after seeing an advertisement for the business by chance, Amir did not answer. Not because he did not remember Moshe. He remembered him precisely. But some people find it harder to receive a good message when they need help than when they need nothing at all.

The bad partner reached him through a friend of a friend. Beside him, once, stood a man in a shirt too white for a construction site, with an old scriptural name Amir immediately forgot and hair the wind arranged as if it knew him better than he knew himself. He did not cheat Amir himself. On the contrary, he shook his hand and said, "A man like you should not be afraid to grow." The sentence was true enough to sound like advice, and not true enough to open the wrong door.

Roni became funny.

Not merely funny. Very funny. He wrote, performed, appeared on shows, learned how to turn every pain into a joke before the pain had time to sit down. People loved him because, near him, they did not have to be heavy. He saved rooms from embarrassment. Saved family dinners from truth. Saved himself, or so he thought, from seriousness.

But jokes are short ropes. They can pull a person above an abyss for a moment; they cannot build him a bridge.

After one performance, in which the audience laughed too hard at a sentence too close to his life, Roni returned home and could not remove the smile from his face. He sat before the mirror until he realized he did not know what expression lived beneath it.

In the morning there was an email from Moshe:

I saw the show. I laughed. I also worried.

Roni did not answer. But he did not delete it.

That night, in the third row, sat a man Roni did not know. There was something too old in him for so small a room, and when the doors opened, a rusty light rested for a moment in his hair. After the show he waited near the exit and said only, "When you almost say the real thing, the audience laughs harder." He did not say whether it was praise or diagnosis. Roni kept the sentence the way a person keeps a match in his pocket.

Neta became almost.

Almost studied literature, but switched to nursing because one needs a profession. Almost moved cities, but her father became ill. Almost fell in love, but the man wanted a woman with fewer open lives behind her. Almost wrote, almost traveled, almost said no.

She was very good at sitting beside beds. People thought this was because she had patience. That was partly true. The other reason was that she knew the power of a small presence when a person is hanging between two things.

She opened the book Moshe had sent on a night after a shift that had been too long. On the first page he had written:

For Neta, who knew then how to give water without asking too many questions.

She cried, not because the sentence was large, but because it was precise in a small place she had almost forgotten was hers.

Someone passed through Neta's life too, someone she later found it hard to prove had mattered even to herself. An old name. A gentle voice. A little redness, perhaps in the hair and perhaps only in the light of that evening. He was almost love, or only the possibility of love. He told her she was good at staying. It was not a bad sentence. Precisely for that reason, it stayed in her too long.

Years passed.

Moshe kept sending his thin strings. A message. A card. A book. An invitation unanswered. Sometimes he felt ridiculous. Sometimes faithful. Sometimes he could not tell the difference.

He thought a great deal about the word debt, and then began to dislike it. Debt makes two people unequal: one gave, one owes. But what happened on the bridge was not like that. The four children did not stand above him as redeemers. They were frightened, clumsy, unready. And he was not only a body being pulled. He also held. He also cried. He also agreed to be pulled.

Two strings met in the middle, and the knot was the redemption.

Not they alone. Not he alone. The knot.

One day, after his foundation received a new and overly ugly building in the city center, Moshe canceled the ceremony. Instead he asked his assistant to find four addresses.

“Are they donors?” she asked.

“No.”

“Beneficiaries?”

Moshe thought about it.

“Not exactly.”

She waited.

“People I have a knot with,” he said.

He sent each of the four a thick envelope, not festive. Inside was an invitation, a travel card, and an old photograph they had not known had been taken: five children on a bridge, one wrapped in an ambulance blanket, four standing around him in the embarrassment of people who already want to go home.

On the back he wrote:

I did not come to repay a debt. I came to see whether the knot still holds.

Yael almost did not go. She had too much to do. Precisely for that reason, she went.

Amir almost threw away the envelope. Then he saw the cord in the photograph. Precisely for that reason, he kept it.

Roni wrote Moshe a crude joke in reply, deleted it, and sent only: When?

Neta read the sentence on the back three times and understood that the word almost would not save her from deciding this time.

They met in the new building, which was less ugly on the inside. Moshe waited for them in a small room, not a hall. On the table he placed an open box. Inside were a faded hair ribbon, a piece of cord, and a thin strap from an old bag. The original knot was no longer there. Time had untied it long ago. But the materials remained.

At first they spoke like people meeting at a school reunion they had not requested. Roni joked. Yael asked if there was coffee. Amir stood with his back to the wall. Neta touched the box and said nothing.

Moshe looked at them and was suddenly fourteen again, but not in the same way. Then he had been hanging from the bridge and could not find the string inside himself. Now he was a rich, known, powerful man, and still felt he was standing before the same knot, asking it not to break.

"I don't know how to say this without making it too large," he said.

"Then say it small," Neta said.

Moshe smiled.

"You did not save me because you loved me. I know that. Sometimes I am even grateful for it. Love would have made it another story. You saw a boy falling and pulled. Then you went on. And that was enough."

No one spoke.

"All these years I thought I had to return something to you. Then I realized that was not right. If I return, I put myself above you or beneath you. But that knot was not above and beneath. It was in the middle."

He took out four thin folders. Not grand contracts. Not checks of salvation. Each held a different offer.

For Yael: a year of people to hold what she had held alone, and a scholarship for a program she had planned for years and never allowed herself to begin.

For Amir: a new partnership, not a gift. A debt that would be closed only if he agreed to let someone else see the numbers and sit beside him while he was ashamed.

For Roni: a room for work with no audience, and a year's pay in which he would not need to make anyone laugh in order to exist.

For Neta: a small house by the sea, not hers forever, only for six months, with a writing desk and someone to replace her on shifts. A place where almost would no longer be enough.

They looked at him as if he had brought them too much and too little at once.

"Why now?" Amir asked.

Moshe looked at the box.

"Because only now did I understand that I cannot redeem you."

Roni laughed almost out of habit.

"Then why did you invite us?"

"Because perhaps the knot can."

It was a strange answer, and so it remained in the room.

Yael began crying quietly. Amir looked away. Roni did not make a joke. Neta, who was good at sitting beside beds, sat beside everyone as though, at last, someone else was sitting beside her too.

Moshe did not feel like a redeemer.

And that, in a way he had not expected, redeemed him a little.

In the end they went out into the street together. Not embraced. Not solved. Not happy in a way that insulted the years. Only together enough that the evening could not claim any one of them had remained entirely alone.

Outside the building, a light rain was falling. On the pavement, near the drain, two small strings someone had lost floated in the water. The water pushed them toward each other, separated them, returned them. For one brief moment they caught around a stone and formed a small, poor, almost ridiculous knot.

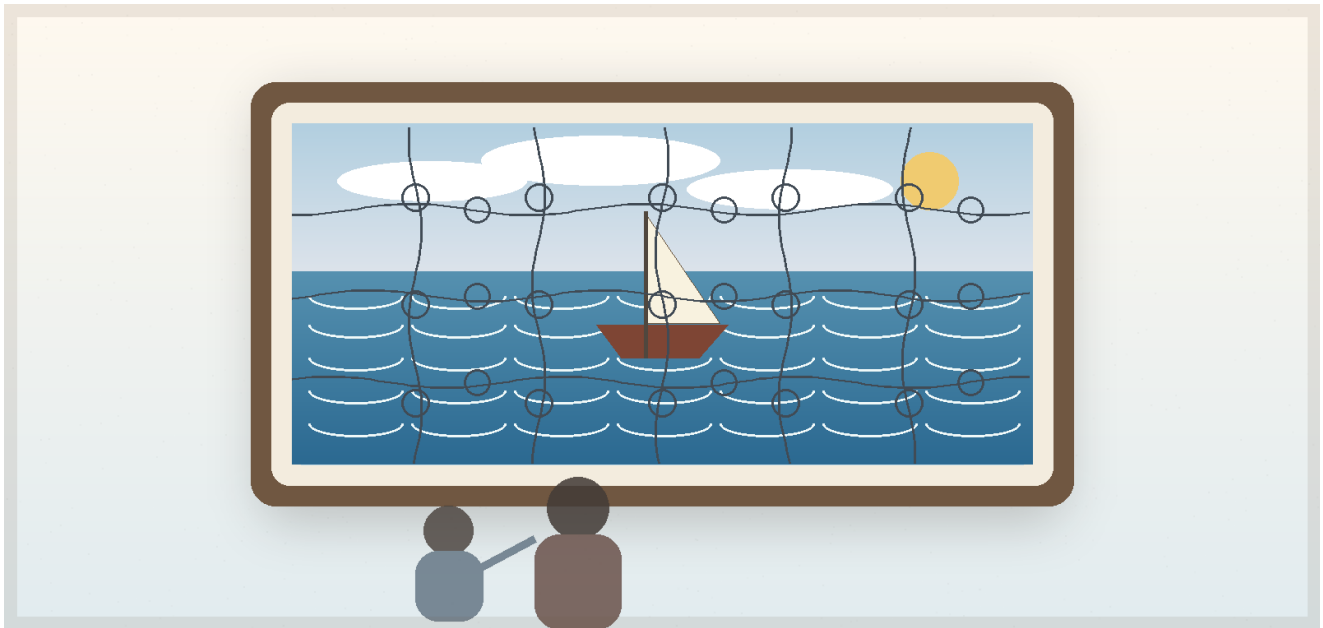
None of them said a word.

But they all saw it.

And Moshe, who had thought for years that he had been saved once on an old bridge, finally understood that redemption had not been the hand that pulled him up. It was the place where two weak strings agreed to be tied, and each became, for a moment, more than it had been alone.

The knot did not promise they would never fray again.

It only proved that tying was possible.



Story Five

Puzzle

How Can a Sea Be Stormy Without Waves



On the wall hung a picture of a stormy sea.

The little boy stood before it for a long time. Up close, the sea was not smooth. It had thin lines in it, small breaks, borders that did not appear in the sea he had once seen for real.

“What is it?” he asked.

His older brother looked for a moment.

“A puzzle.”

The little boy nodded, as though he had received an answer.

“Oh,” he said. “Puzzles.”

His older brother turned to him.

“No. Puzzle.”

The little boy looked at the picture again.

“One?”

“Yes.”

He stepped a little closer.

“Even the lines?”

His older brother made a face.

“What lines?”

The boy pointed without touching the glass.

“Those.”

“That’s how it is in a puzzle.”

“Then why not puzzles?”

His older brother sighed.

“Because you say puzzle.”

“Who says?”

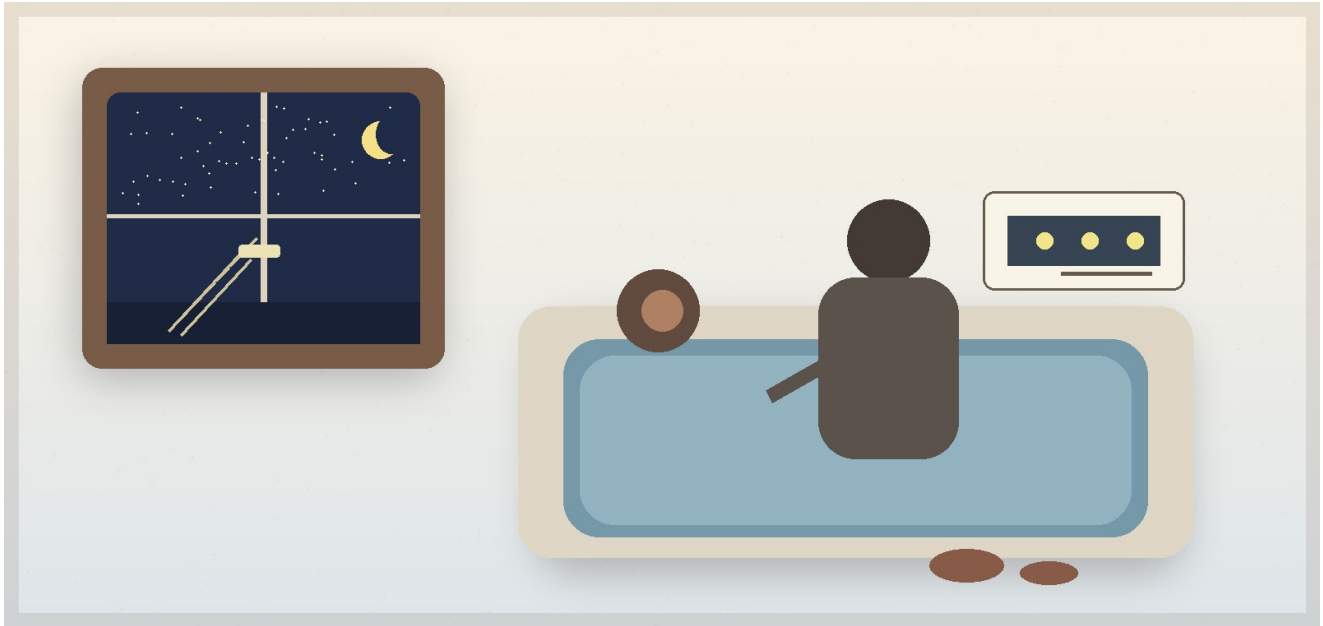
His older brother straightened a little.

“I’m in second grade,” he said. “I know.”

The little boy nodded, because it really did sound like a reason.

Then he went back to looking at the sea.

From far away it was almost ordinary.



Story Six

To Believe in Intruders, or Talk to Computers

One Bare Foot



“Dad,” she said, “I’m afraid to sleep.”

Her father was already by the door, his hand on the light switch.

“But your brother is in the room with you,” he said. “What are you afraid of?”

She pulled the blanket up to her chin.

“Intruders.”

Her father gave a small smile, not because he was laughing at her, but because he wanted the fear to look smaller to her. He went to the window, opened it a little, and pointed outside.

“Look where we are,” he said. “Third floor. Very, very high. How would intruders get up here?”

She looked outside seriously.

“With a ladder.”

Her father paused.

“True,” he said carefully. “But there isn’t a ladder that long. From the street to here? No. You don’t need to worry.”

She thought about that for a moment.

“Then he’ll climb to the top.”

“Who?”

“The intruder.”

“On the ladder?”

She nodded.

“And when he gets to the top, he’ll take tape and stick the ladder higher. Then he’ll keep climbing.”

Her father opened his mouth, closed it, and looked outside again, as though he might actually have missed an important clause in the laws of ladders.

“I don’t think ladders work like that,” he said.

“But tape sticks.”

“Not ladders to a wall on the third floor.”

“Maybe he has strong tape.”

Her father closed the window.

“My beautiful girl, if an intruder comes with a ladder like that and tape like that, I think he’s not an intruder anymore. He’s an engineer.”

She did not laugh right away. Then she smiled a little, just to show she had heard the joke, but her eyes were still checking the window.

“I’m still afraid of intruders.”

Her father sat on the edge of her bed.

“You are not alone. I’m in the next room. Mom is home. Grandpa and Grandma are close. Uncle and Aunt. Your brother is here. We are all watching over you.”

She listened.

“And do you know what will happen if an intruder comes?” her father asked.

She looked at him.

Her father opened his mouth very, very wide, too wide, and moved toward her slowly.

“I’ll eat him!”

She laughed.

Then she stopped laughing a little too quickly.

“Dad, that’s weird.”

“True,” he said. “But it worked for a second.”

She smiled, and then went quiet.

Her father already thought the fear had fallen asleep before she had, but then she said:

“Dad?”

“Yes?”

“I’m afraid I’ll never learn to read.”

He looked at her.

“Why do you think that?”

“Because all the kids in my class read better than me. And I can’t do it. I’m only good at math.”

Her father moved a little closer.

“You will learn to read,” he said. “Everyone learns in the end. Everyone in their own time. And when you do learn, you’ll know it’s something you truly managed to do. We learn so many things in life. Learning isn’t scary. Learning is fun.”

She thought about that quietly.

Then she said:

“But what if intruders come?”

Her father breathed in, like someone trying not to open his mouth too wide for a second time.

“There are also guards,” he said. “There are guards at the entrance to the community. And there are guards at your school. People watch over us all the time.”

“All the time?”

“All the time.”

“Even at night?”

“Even at night.”

She looked a little calmer.

Then her father added, without realizing he was about to replace one fear with another:

“And one day, maybe when you and your brother are grown, maybe you’ll also be in the army. There’s something there called shin-gimel, a guard post. You stand and guard.”

She sat up at once.

“I don’t want to go to the army.”

“Not now,” her father said immediately. “When you’re grown.”

“I don’t want to.”

“It isn’t necessarily a bad thing.”

“If someone doesn’t go to the army, do they go to jail?”

Her father realized too late that he had entered the wrong room inside her head.

“If someone has a valid reason, then no,” he said. “And if they don’t have a valid reason, then sometimes yes. But you don’t need to think about that now.”

She was thinking about it now.

“What if I don’t want to?”

“Maybe by then there will be peace,” he said.

She looked at him with a small, serious expression, much too serious for a girl who was still afraid of ladders.

“And if there isn’t peace?”

Her father was quiet for a moment.

“Then, worst case, you can say you’re a pacifist.”

“Passifist?”

“Pacifist.”

“Passifistit?”

“Almost.”

“What is it?”

“It’s someone who believes they don’t want to fight. Someone who doesn’t believe in wars.”

She tried to say it again.

“Paci... fis...”

“Pacifist.”

“But Dad,” she said, “how will I tell them? I can’t even say the word.”

Her father laughed, this time for real.

“You’re going to learn so many things in life, my beautiful girl. And it’s fun. Do you know what Dad does at work?”

“No.”

“Dad talks to computers.”

She looked at him as though he had just told her he also ate intruders at lunch.

“Dad, you’re funny. Computers don’t talk.”

“True,” he said. “Not like we talk. But Dad knows how to talk to them. He knows how to ask them a question, how to give them a task, how to explain rules to them.”

She sat up straighter.

“Can I learn?”

“Of course.”

Her father looked around the room for an example. On the floor, near the bed, there was one slipper.

He picked it up.

“Let’s say I tell the computer this: if the girl has one shoe, she can’t go to school. But if the girl has two shoes, she can go to school.”

She listened carefully.

Her father placed one shoe on the floor.

“Now I ask the computer: there is one shoe. Can the girl go to school?”

“No,” she said.

“Good. And now if there are two shoes?”

He picked up the second slipper and placed it beside the first.

“Can the girl go to school?”

“Yes.”

“Exactly. That’s like talking to a computer. You give it a rule, and then you ask it. Did you understand, my beautiful girl?”

She nodded.

“What did you understand?”

She looked at the two slippers.

Then at her father.

“That if I don’t want to go to school,” she said, “I can hide one shoe.”

Her father opened his mouth to answer.

This time, no intruder came out.

Only a small laugh, tired and happy.

“Okay, my beautiful girl,” he said. “Then I want you to do something for me now.”

“What?”

“Try to think of a story. Now, before you fall asleep. A story about a computer you can talk to. What it looks like, where it lives, what it answers when people ask it things. And in the morning, you’ll tell it to me.”

She pulled the blanket up to her chin and thought about it seriously.

“But Dad,” she said at last, “I only know how to tell stories about...”

She stopped.

“About what?”

She searched for the right word and did not find it.

“About la-la-la.”

Her father smiled.

“La-la-la,” he repeated quietly.

“That sounds woolly and purple to me.”

She looked at him for a moment, as if checking whether he was laughing at her.

But he was not laughing.

So she turned onto her side, with one bare foot a little outside the blanket.

And the room grew quiet.

Not because the intruders were gone.

Not because the questions were gone.

But because that night, at least, she had la-la-la to think about.

*If you are not aware of the beginning,
how will you find the end?*